

BPO: Bayesian Preference Optimization for *Multiobjective Discrete Optimization*

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Code + Slides: <https://github.com/rahulptel/BPO>



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Multiobjective Discrete Optimization (MODO)

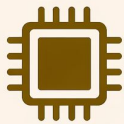
Applications



1. Facility Location Planning



2. Vehicle Routing and Scheduling



3. Feature Selection in Machine Learning



4. Course Timetabling in Education



5. Portfolio Optimization



6. Treatment Planning

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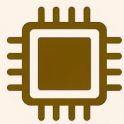
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Math. Formulation

$$\min_{\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{X} \subset \mathbb{Z}^N} \left(f_1(\mathbf{x}), f_2(\mathbf{x}), \dots, f_K(\mathbf{x}) \right)$$

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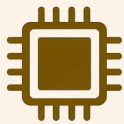
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Decision variables

Conflicting objectives

Discrete feasible set

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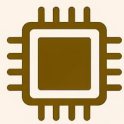
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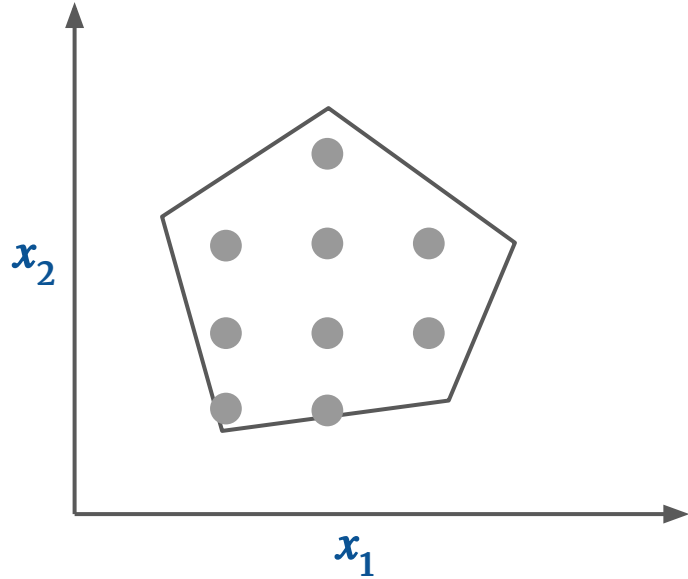
Conflicting objectives

Discrete feasible set

- Solutions represent tradeoffs
- No single winner
- **Goal:** Enumerate Pareto frontier

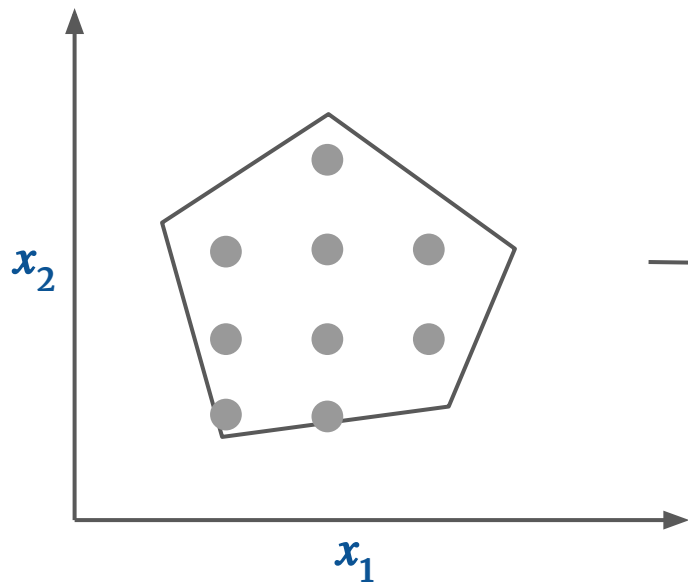
Decision Space and Objective Space in MODO

Decision Space $\mathcal{X}$

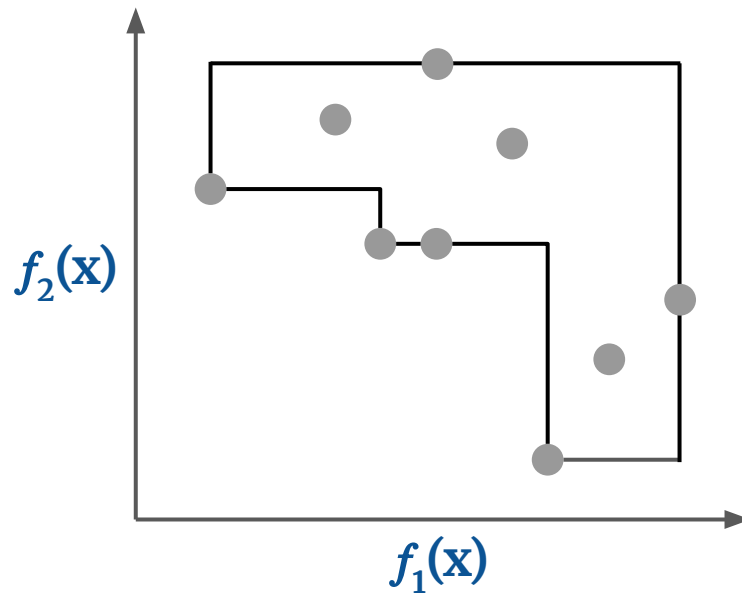


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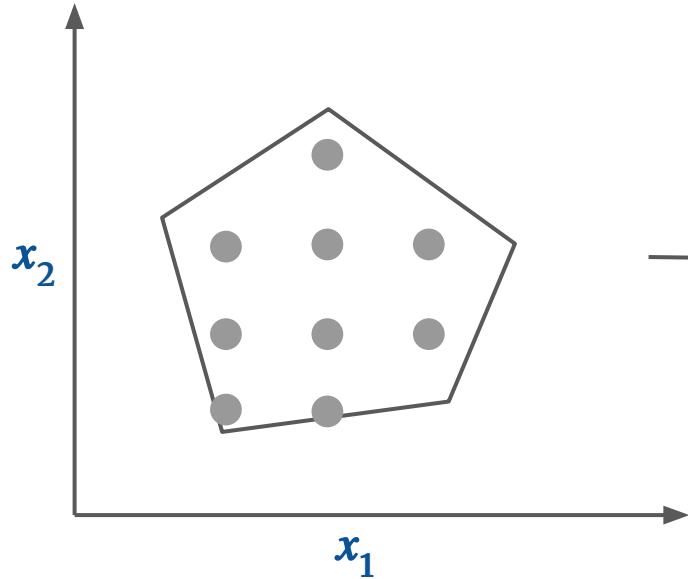


Objective Space

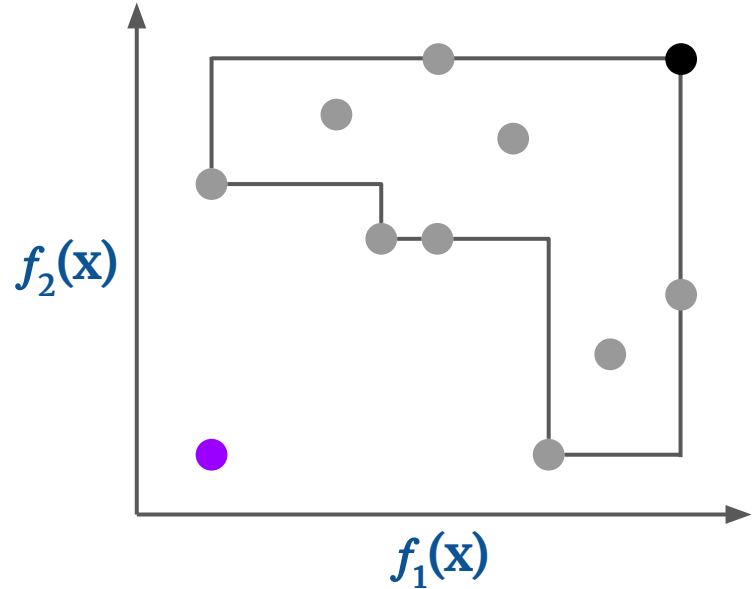


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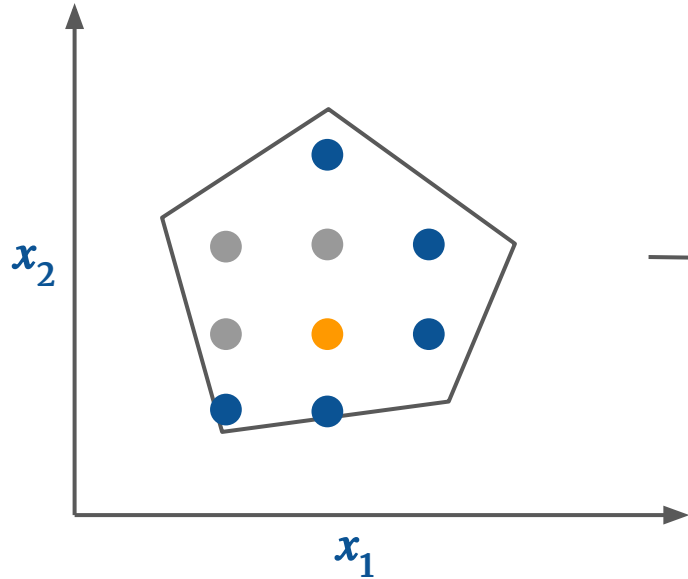


● Nadir point

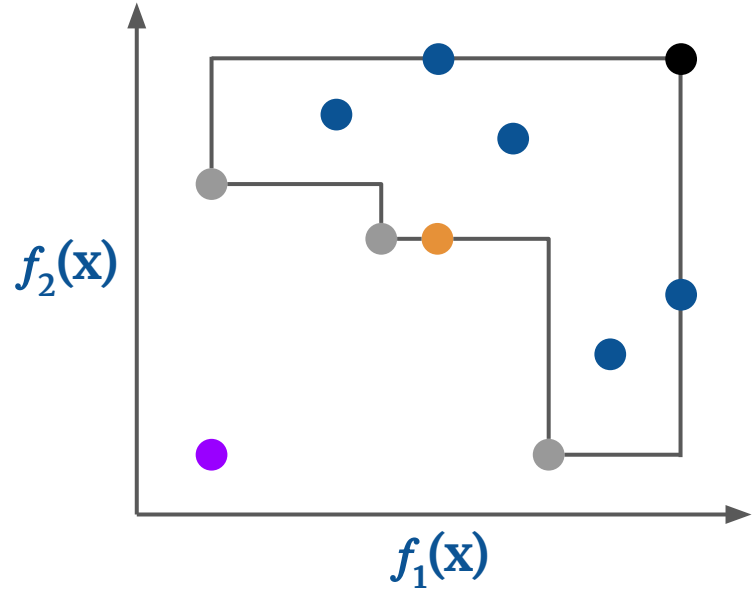
● Ideal point

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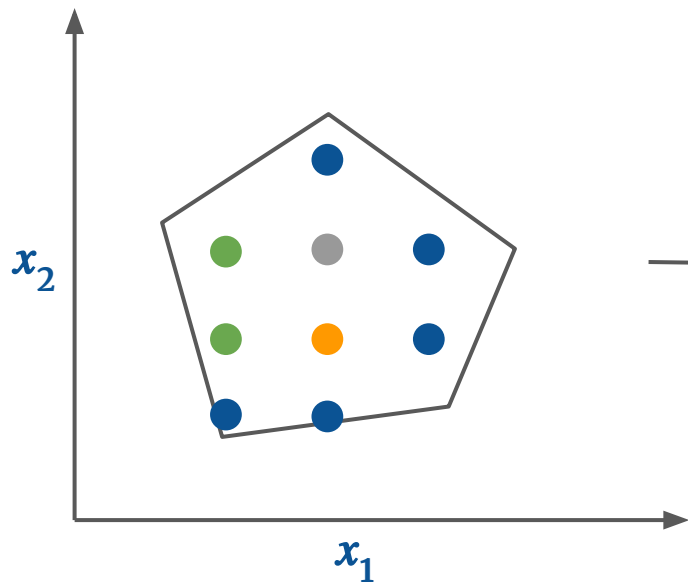
Objective Space



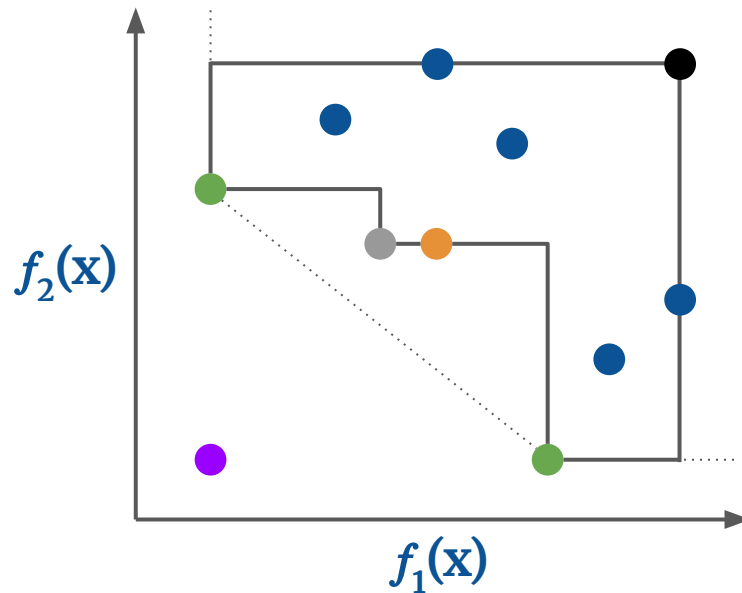
- Nadir point
- Dominated point
- Ideal point
- Weakly nondominated point

Decision Space and Objective Space in MODO

Decision Space $\mathcal{X}$



Objective Space



● Nadir point

● Dominated point

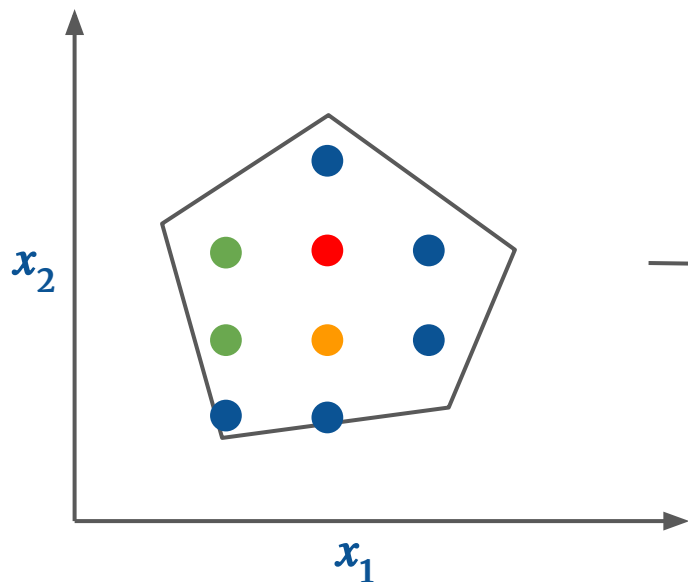
● Supported nondominated point

● Ideal point

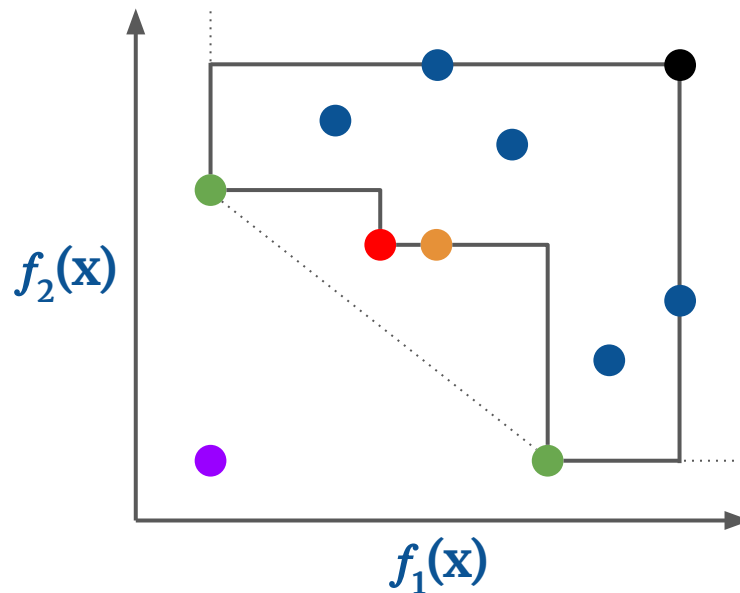
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Objective Space



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● Weakly nondominated point

● Unsupported nondominated point

Solution Approaches to MODO problems

Exact Methods

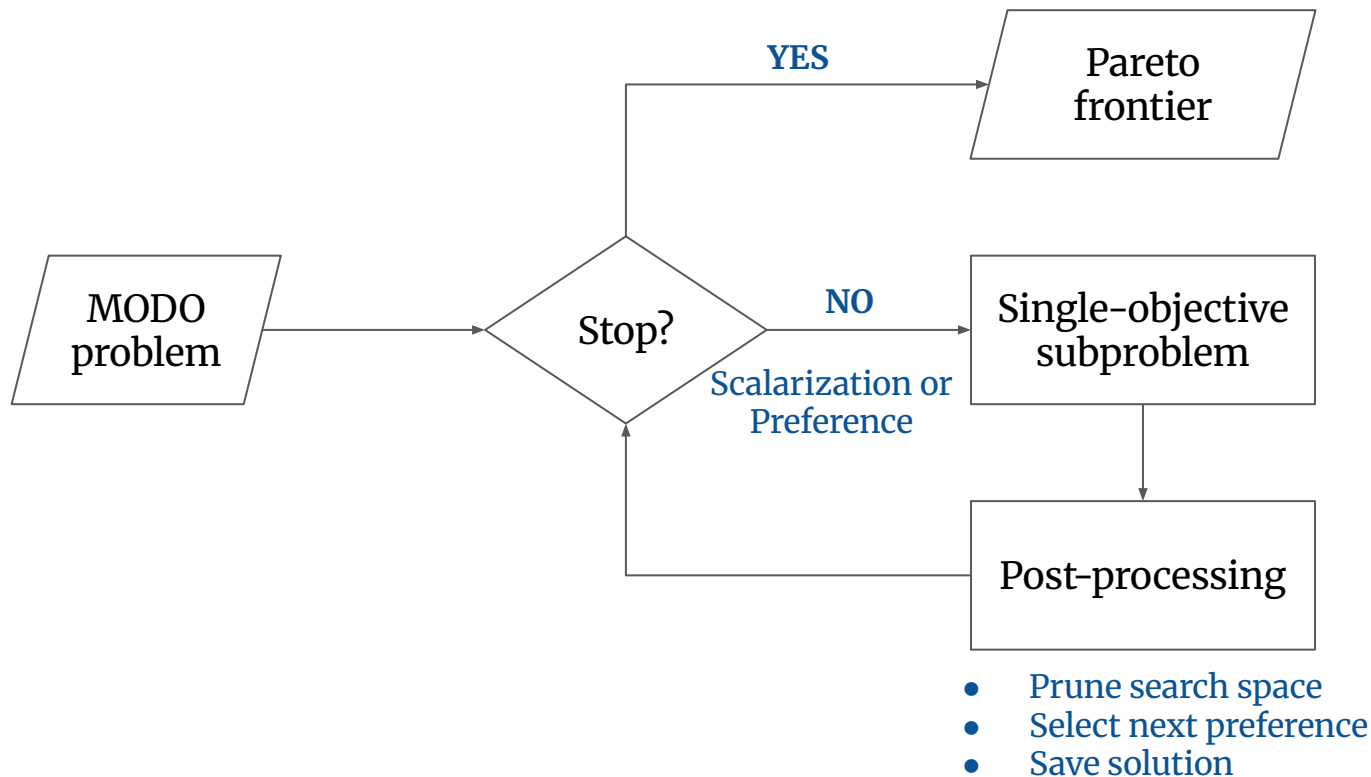
- **Objective Space Search**
Kirlik and Sayin (2014)
Boland et al. (2015)
- **Decision Space Search**
Mavrotas and Danae (1998)
Adelgren and Gupte (2017)
- **Dynamic Programming**
Bergman et al. (2022)

Survey on exact MODO approaches:
Halffmann et al. (2022)

Heuristic Methods

- **Matheuristics**
Pal and Charkhgard (2019)
An et al. (2024)
- **Evolutionary Algorithms**
Deb et al. (2002)
Zhang and Li (2007)
- **Machine Learning**
Li et al. (2021)
Lin et al. (2022)

MOD0 Solution Schematic: A High-Level Overview

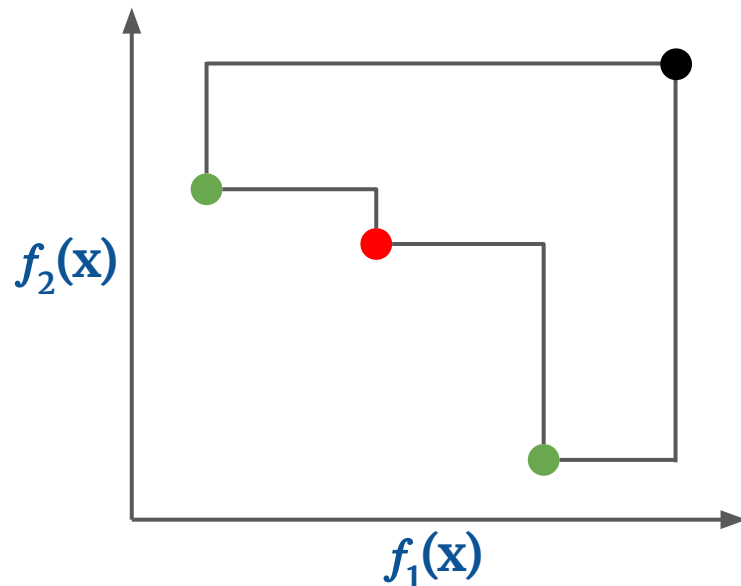


Scalarized Subproblem: Weighted-Sum Scalarization

$$\min_{\mathbf{x} \in X} \left(\sum_{i=1}^m \lambda_i f_i(\mathbf{x}) \right)$$

$$\lambda_i \geq 0, \quad \sum_{i=1}^m \lambda_i = 1$$

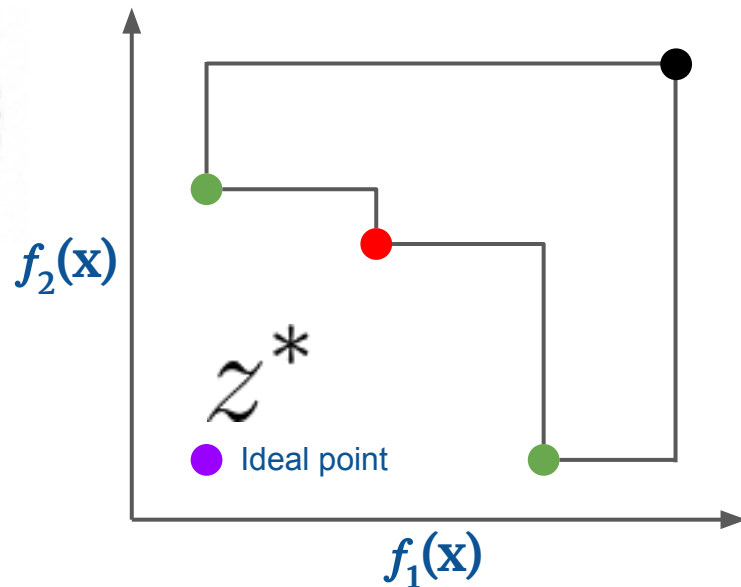
Recovers supported nondominated points but misses the unsupported ones



Ehrgott (2005)

Scalarized Subproblem: Augmented Tchebycheff Scalarization (ATS)

$$\min_{\mathbf{x} \in X} \left(\max_{i \in \{1, \dots, m\}} \lambda_i (f_i(\mathbf{x}) - z_i^*) + \rho \sum_{i=1}^m \lambda_i (f_i(\mathbf{x}) - z_i^*) \right)$$

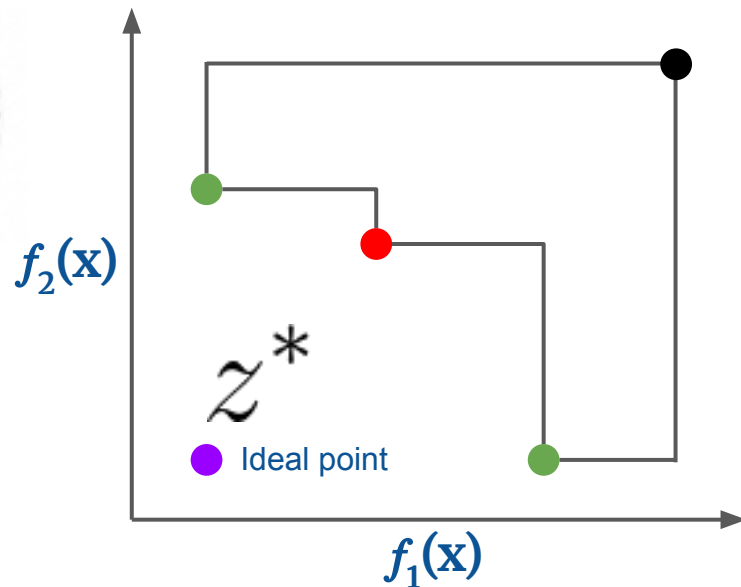


Steuer and Choo (1983)

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- Recovers supported and unsupported nondominated points

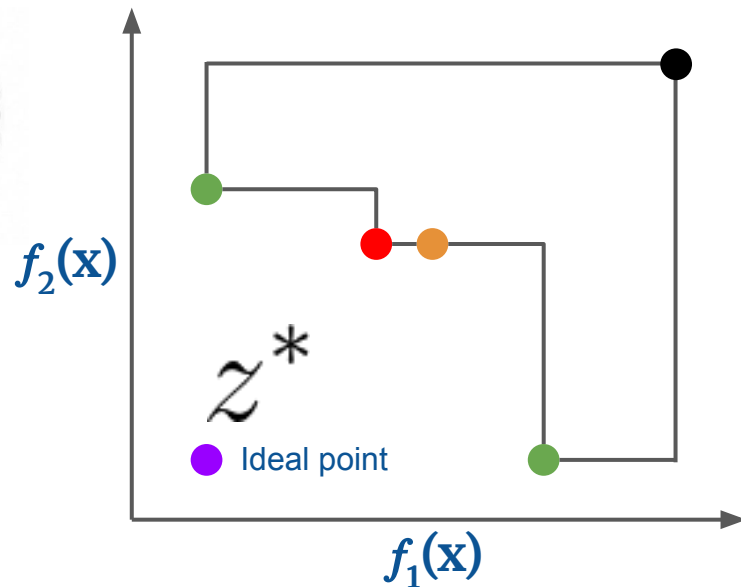


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- Recovers supported and unsupported nondominated points
- Avoids weakly nondominated points



Great explainer: Tripp, Austin. 2025. "Chebyshev Scalarization Explained." May 12. <https://austintripp.ca/blog/2025-05-12-chebyshev-scalarization/>.

Steuer and Choo (1983)

Limitations

Exact Methods

- Do not scale for large problems
- Focused on enumeration thus could return a subset of the Pareto frontier that lacks diversity

Heuristic Methods

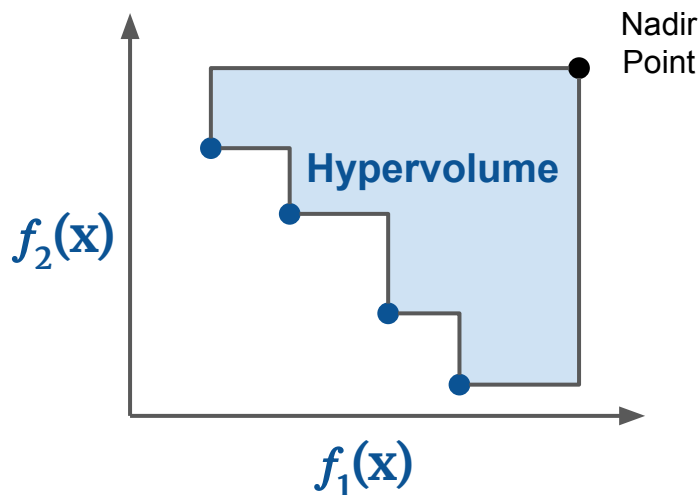
- Struggle to handle hard constraints
- Uniformly sampled preferences
- Static set of preferences

GOAL

Generate high-quality approximate Pareto frontier
as quickly as possible

How to **adaptively** select preferences
in a principled way?

How to Quantify the Goodness of a Preference?



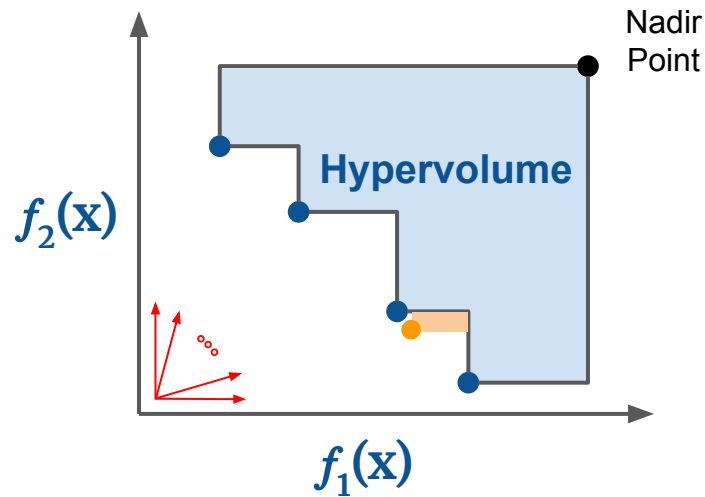
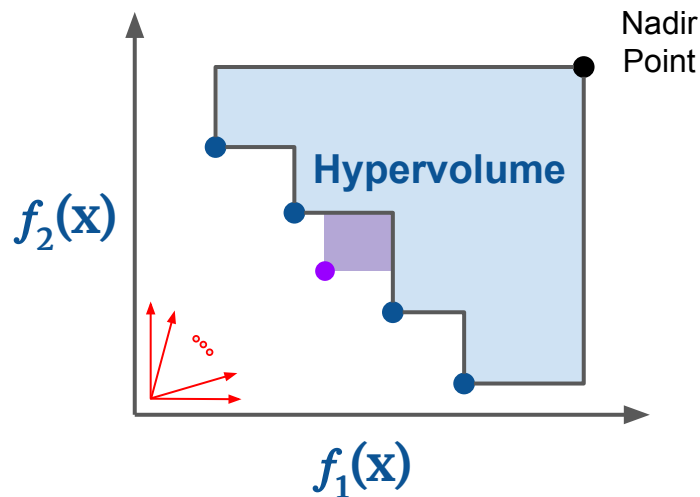
Hypervolume: Volume of the region dominated by non-dominated solutions set relative to a nadir point.

Property: the higher the hypervolume, the better the approximation

Goal

Given (preference, objective vector) pairs, select a new preference such that the improvement in hypervolume is maximized

How to Select Preferences?



Select a **preference** that results in the **purple point**

Preference Optimization as a Bilevel Problem

$$\max_{\mathbf{y}, \mathbf{x}, \boldsymbol{\lambda}} \quad \Phi(\mathcal{Y}_k \cup \{\mathbf{y}\})$$

$$\text{s.t.} \quad \mathbf{y} = f(\mathbf{x}),$$

$$\mathbf{x} = \arg \min_{\mathbf{x}' \in \mathcal{X}} \left(\max_{i \in \{1, \dots, m\}} \lambda_i (f_i(\mathbf{x}') - z_i^*) + \rho \sum_{i=1}^m \lambda_i (f_i(\mathbf{x}') - z_i^*) \right),$$

$$\boldsymbol{\lambda} \in \boldsymbol{\Lambda}.$$

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$$\boldsymbol{\lambda} \in \Lambda.$$

Select a preference ...

Preference Optimization as a Bilevel Problem

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Select a preference with an objective vector ...

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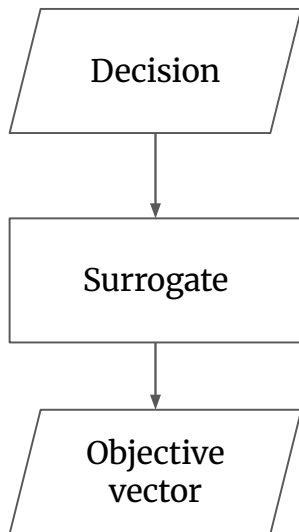
Select a preference with an objective vector **that maximizes the improvement in Pareto frontier quality**

Formulate **next** preference selection as a
Bayesian optimization problem

Surrogate Modeling using Gaussian Process

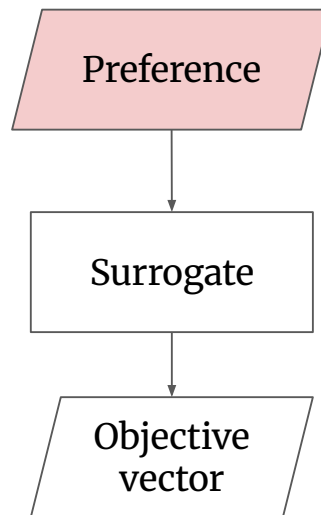
Traditional Multiobjective BO

Assumption: Evaluating a decision is hard



Bayesian Preference Optimization

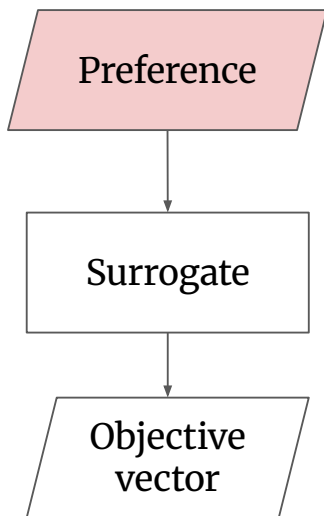
Assumption: Finding good quality decision is hard



Surrogate Modeling using Gaussian Process

Bayesian Preference Optimization

Assumption: Finding good quality decision is hard



Benefits

1. **Scalability** w.r.t the number of variables
2. Ability to handle **mixed-integer variables**

Acquisition Function: Expected Hypervolume Improvement

$$\Phi_{\text{qEHVI}} = \mathbb{E}_{f(\Lambda)|\mathcal{D}} [\text{HV}(\mathcal{Y} \cup f(\Lambda)) - \text{HV}(\mathcal{Y})]$$

- Uses box decomposition of the non-dominated region to compute hypervolume improvement
- Uses a differentiable Monte Carlo estimator, enabling gradient-based acquisition optimization

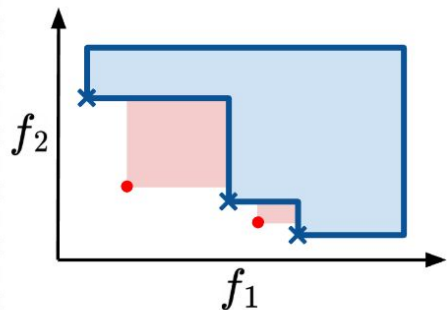
Daulton et al. (2020)

Bayesian Preference Optimization: Active Learning Loop

1. Data Collection

Solve scalarization subproblems

Obtain approximate Pareto Frontier

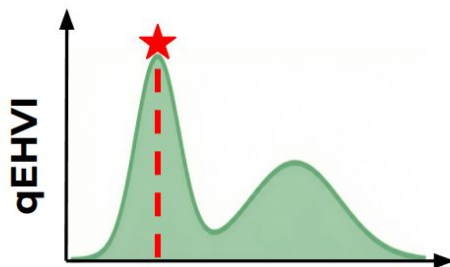


- Dominated Region
- Hypervolume improvement
- × Recovered nondominated point (NDP)
- Unrecovered NDP

2. Gaussian Process Surrogate Training

$$p(f(\lambda)|\mathcal{D}, \lambda) = \mathcal{N}(\mu_{f(\lambda)}, \sigma_{f(\lambda)})$$

3. Acquisition Optimization



$$\lambda_1 \in [0, 1]$$
$$\lambda_1 : \lambda_1 + \lambda_2 = 1$$

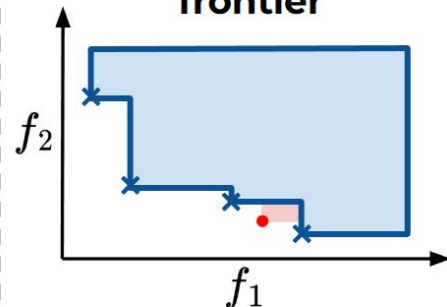
qEHVI peaks when $\lambda_1 = 0.2$ preference

4. Solve Subproblem



Solve ATS with preference optimized using qEHVI

5. Updated Pareto frontier



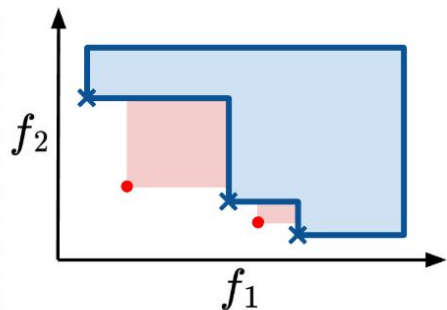
Recovered NDP that maximizes EHVI

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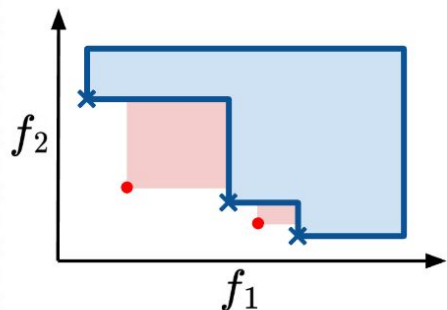
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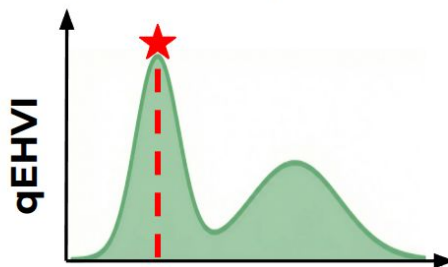


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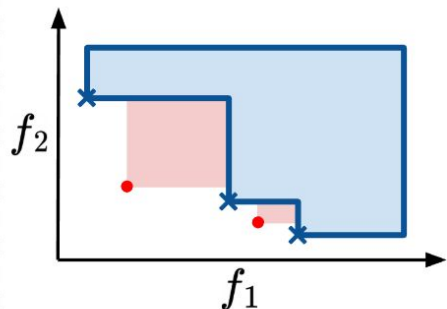
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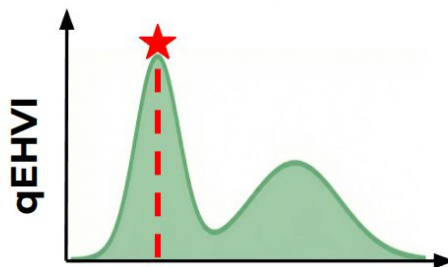


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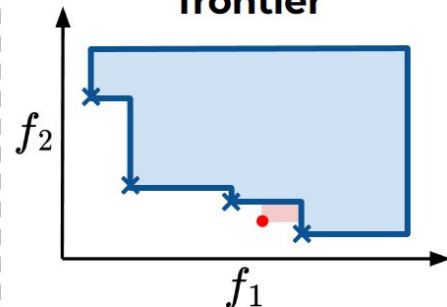
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Bayesian Preference Optimization: Active Learning Loop

Algorithm 1: The BPO Framework

Data: Number of initial samples N_{init} , number of main iterations N_{iter} , surrogate model $\mathcal{M}$, acquisition function α

Result: Approximate Pareto frontier $\mathcal{Y}$

```
1  $\mathcal{Y} \leftarrow \emptyset, \mathcal{D} \leftarrow \emptyset$ 
2 Sample  $\{\boldsymbol{\lambda}^i\}_{i=1}^{N_{\text{init}}} \sim \text{Dirichlet}(\mathbf{1})$ 
3 for  $k = 1, \dots, N_{\text{init}}$  do
4   Solve scalarized problem with parameter  $\boldsymbol{\lambda}^k$  and obtain  $\mathbf{y}^k$ 
5    $\mathcal{Y} \leftarrow \mathcal{Y} \cup \{\mathbf{y}^k\}, \mathcal{D} \leftarrow \mathcal{D} \cup \{(\boldsymbol{\lambda}^k, \mathbf{y}^k)\}$ 
6 Train surrogate model  $\mathcal{M}$  using dataset  $\mathcal{D}$ 
7 for  $k = 1, \dots, N_{\text{iter}}$  do
8    $\boldsymbol{\lambda}^* \leftarrow \arg \max_{\boldsymbol{\lambda} \in \Lambda} \alpha(\boldsymbol{\lambda} \mid \mathcal{M})$ 
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10   $\mathcal{Y} \leftarrow \mathcal{Y} \cup \{\mathbf{y}^*\}, \mathcal{D} \leftarrow \mathcal{D} \cup \{(\boldsymbol{\lambda}^*, \mathbf{y}^*)\}$ 
11  Retrain surrogate model  $\mathcal{M}$  using dataset  $\mathcal{D}$ 
12 Return  $\mathcal{Y}$ 
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**Dataset generation
and initial training**

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```

1. Find hypervolume maximizing preference
2. Solve subproblem
3. Update dataset
4. Retrain

Computational Setup

- **Problems:** Multiobjective **knapsack** and **assignment**
- 7 different sizes per problem
- 25 problems per size (n: #variables, m: #objectives)
- **Methods**
 - KSA (Exact)
 - NSGA-II (Evolutionary algorithm)
 - ATS (randomly sampled preferences)
 - BPO-100 & BPO-150 (100/150 initial preferences)

Approximation Quality: BPO vs Baselines

MOKP								MOAP									
m	n	Method	Hypervolume %					$ \hat{\mathcal{Y}}_N $	m	n	Method	Hypervolume %					$ \hat{\mathcal{Y}}_N $
			Mean.	Std.	Min.	Max.	Iter.					Mean.	Std.	Min.	Max.	Iter.	
3	1250	KSA	64.75	1.65	62.45	68.24	708	706	3	200	KSA	74.11	1.19	70.93	76.64	626	625
		NSGA-II	85.57	0.58	84.15	86.80	–	200			NSGA-II	47.68	1.25	45.00	51.86	–	200
		ATS	95.49	0.42	94.18	96.24	217	215			ATS	96.15	1.99	74.78	97.14	185	185
		BPO-100	96.80	0.20	96.29	97.23	362	159			BPO-100	97.36	0.37	95.93	97.80	193	163
		BPO-150	96.73	0.57	94.18	97.28	296	183			BPO-150	97.01	0.71	95.05	97.88	184	173
6	500	KSA	29.49	2.54	22.89	35.20	26	24	7	50	KSA	2.88	0.00	2.88	2.88	26	18
		NSGA-II	65.10	1.85	58.91	69.45	–	200			NSGA-II	8.24	0.49	7.07	9.65	–	200
		ATS	77.75	1.44	73.15	80.60	118	118			ATS	39.89	2.26	34.94	46.77	233	233
		BPO-100	79.80	2.83	72.26	84.90	113	107			BPO-100	37.13	1.51	34.44	42.21	170	159
		BPO-150	78.26	1.82	74.22	84.80	116	115			BPO-150	38.73	1.70	34.85	43.95	187	182

BPO achieves better hypervolume compared to baselines

Approximation Quality: BPO vs ATS in Parallel Mode

MOKP							MOAP								
		Hypervolume %							Hypervolume %						
m	n	Method	Mean.	Std.	Min.	Max.	$ \hat{\mathcal{Y}}_N $	m	n	Method	Mean.	Std.	Min.	Max.	$ \hat{\mathcal{Y}}_N $
3	1250	ATS	96.36	0.20	95.94	96.74	1067	3	200	ATS	97.49	0.11	97.27	97.68	916
		BPO-100	97.09	0.18	96.75	97.46	771			BPO-100	98.18	0.08	98.01	98.30	740
		BPO-150	97.10	0.18	96.77	97.47	895			BPO-150	98.20	0.09	97.98	98.35	831
		Oracle	97.15	0.18	96.81	97.51	2180			Oracle	98.31	0.08	98.14	98.43	1848
6	500	ATS	82.02	0.96	79.86	83.81	591	7	50	ATS	47.46	1.82	44.37	52.95	1164
		BPO-100	84.75	1.72	80.73	87.53	529			BPO-100	45.86	1.52	43.59	50.40	773
		BPO-150	83.11	1.31	81.45	87.38	577			BPO-150	46.91	1.59	44.13	51.66	903
		Oracle	85.26	1.51	81.66	87.96	761			Oracle	49.06	1.92	45.99	54.80	1564

BPO achieves better hypervolume compared to ATS in parallel mode

Approximation Quality: BPO vs Oracle

MOKP							MOAP								
		Hypervolume %							Hypervolume %						
m	n	Method	Mean.	Std.	Min.	Max.	$ \hat{\mathcal{Y}}_N $	m	n	Method	Mean.	Std.	Min.	Max.	$ \hat{\mathcal{Y}}_N $
3	1250	ATS	96.36	0.20	95.94	96.74	1067	3	200	ATS	97.49	0.11	97.27	97.68	916
		BPO-100	97.09	0.18	96.75	97.46	771			BPO-100	98.18	0.08	98.01	98.30	740
		BPO-150	97.10	0.18	96.77	97.47	895			BPO-150	98.20	0.09	97.98	98.35	831
		Oracle	97.15	0.18	96.81	97.51	2180			Oracle	98.31	0.08	98.14	98.43	1848
6	500	ATS	82.02	0.96	79.86	83.81	591	7	50	ATS	47.46	1.82	44.37	52.95	1164
		BPO-100	84.75	1.72	80.73	87.53	529			BPO-100	45.86	1.52	43.59	50.40	773
		BPO-150	83.11	1.31	81.45	87.38	577			BPO-150	46.91	1.59	44.13	51.66	903
		Oracle	85.26	1.51	81.66	87.96	761			Oracle	49.06	1.92	45.99	54.80	1564

BPO attains hypervolume close to that of the Oracle

Concluding Remarks

- We proposed **BPO**, a principled framework for sample-efficient preference selection aimed at maximizing Pareto frontier quality
- BPO **scales** with number of variables
- BPO is **sample-efficient** compared to baselines and achieves better hypervolume
- **Future work:** Make BPO scalable with the number of objectives

Code + Slides: <https://github.com/rahulptel/BPO>

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